

Songkran: Reading and Speaking Pack

One topic, three reading levels (A2, B1, B2), with exercises, a dialogue and speaking tasks

ESL / EFL · WHAT'S INSIDE

- The same reading at three levels (A2, B1, B2), with the same core facts
- Graded exercises for each level, with an answer key
- A model dialogue and role-play, and pair speaking tasks
- Teacher notes, and pages showing how the pack was checked

Teacher notes

One topic, three levels. Songkran is the Thai New Year. The three readings carry the same core facts, so a mixed-level class can work on one topic and then talk to each other.

The three readings

Level	Words	Words per sentence	Reading grade*
A2	140	7	3.9
B1	228	15	8.9
B2	289	21	11.9

**Flesch-Kincaid grade, measured on the final texts. It is a rough guide only: the level was set by vocabulary and grammar, then measured.*

A 60-minute plan

5 min Warm up: What do you know about Thai festivals? What festivals do you celebrate?

10 min Students read their level and do the first exercise.

15 min Jigsaw: pair a student from each level. Each tells the other the three most interesting facts, without looking at the text.

15 min Dialogue: read, find the advice phrases, then role-play.

15 min Speaking: 'My festival' pair task and discussion questions.

Notes

The texts say 'traditionally' because customs differ by region and family. Local celebrations may run longer than 13 to 15 April.

Pictures: replace the grey placeholders with your own photos or images (right-click, Change Picture). The captions say 'Illustration created with AI' for that reason; edit them if you change the image.

The answer key is on page 11. Delete it before sharing the file with students.

Songkran: Reading A2

LEVEL A2

Before you read

1. What do you know about Thai festivals?
2. Look at the picture. What can you see?



Songkran is the Thai New Year. It is on 13, 14 and 15 April. In Thailand, this is the hottest time of the year.

Water is the most important part of Songkran. Water means a fresh start. People clean their homes and their Buddha images. They wash away the old year.

Many families go home for Songkran. They visit their grandparents. They pour a little water on their grandparents' hands to show respect. The old people give them a blessing. Families also go to the temple and give food to monks.

Today, Songkran is also a big water party. People play in the street with water guns and buckets. Everyone gets wet! But there are rules. Do not throw water at monks, babies or old people. Put your phone in a waterproof bag.

In 2023, UNESCO added Songkran to its list of cultural heritage.

Songkran: Reading B1

LEVEL B1

Before you read

1. Which festivals do you celebrate with your family?
2. What do you think the water means in Songkran?



Songkran is the traditional Thai New Year, celebrated every year from 13 to 15 April. The word comes from Sanskrit and means "movement" or "passing", because the festival marks the time when the sun moves into a new position in the sky. April is also the hottest month in Thailand, so a festival about water arrives at exactly the right moment.

For many Thai people, the festival begins quietly. On 13 April, people go to the temple and gently pour water over Buddha images. They also give food to monks and clean their homes. The water is a symbol of washing away bad luck and starting the new year fresh.

Family is at the heart of Songkran. Millions of people travel from the cities to their home towns to see their relatives. Traditionally, younger people pour scented water over the hands of their grandparents and parents, as a sign of respect, and the older people give them a blessing in return.

In recent years, Songkran has become famous for its huge water fights. Streets fill with people carrying water guns, and almost nobody stays dry. However, there are some unwritten rules. You should not splash monks, babies, elderly people or people on motorbikes, and you should keep valuable things in a waterproof bag.

In December 2023, UNESCO added Songkran to its list of intangible cultural heritage, recognising it as a living tradition.

Useful words

scented: with a pleasant smell

blessing: good wishes, often given by an older or religious person

intangible: something you cannot touch, such as a tradition or a custom

Songkran: Reading B2

LEVEL B2

Before you read

1. Why might a festival about water happen in April?
2. How do tourism and tradition affect each other at festivals you know?



Songkran, the traditional Thai New Year, is celebrated each year from 13 to 15 April. Its name derives from the Sanskrit word for "passing" or "movement", a reference to the sun's passage into a new position in the zodiac. Falling in what is usually the hottest month of the year in Thailand, it is, not coincidentally, a festival built around water.

Beneath the fun, the water carries a serious meaning: cleansing, respect and good fortune. Early in the festival, people traditionally make merit at the temple, where they offer food to monks and sprinkle water on Buddha images. Another well-known custom is the pouring of scented water over the hands of elders, a gesture of reverence that is answered with a blessing. For many families, this is often the one time of the year when several generations are under the same roof, which helps explain why bus stations and roads are so crowded in the days before the holiday.

The public face of Songkran has changed considerably. In cities and tourist towns, the festival is now best known for enormous street water fights, which have attracted visitors from all over the world. This has prompted discussion in Thailand about whether the spirit of the festival is being lost, and about the safety of crowded roads. Most people, though, see no contradiction: they spend the morning at the temple and the afternoon getting soaked.

Visitors who want to join in respectfully are advised to follow simple etiquette. Avoid splashing monks, babies, elderly people and anyone riding a motorbike, wear quick-drying clothes, and protect your phone. In December 2023, UNESCO inscribed Songkran on its Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity, recognising the living tradition that continues beneath the festivities.

Useful words

zodiac: the twelve star signs used to divide the sky
festivities: the celebrations and events during a holiday
etiquette: accepted rules of polite behaviour
contradiction: two things that cannot both be true

Exercises: Level A2

Name: _____ Date: _____

A. True or false? Circle T or F.

1. Songkran is in December. T / F
2. Songkran is in the hottest time of the year in Thailand. T / F
3. People pour water on their grandparents' hands. T / F
4. You can throw water at monks. T / F
5. UNESCO added Songkran to its list in 2023. T / F

B. Match the word to its meaning. Write the letter.

- | | | |
|----------------|-------|--|
| 1. temple | _____ | A. a man who lives and prays at a temple |
| 2. monk | _____ | B. water cannot get through it |
| 3. blessing | _____ | C. a building where people pray |
| 4. waterproof | _____ | D. good wishes, often from an older person |
| 5. fresh start | _____ | E. a new beginning |

C. Answer the questions.

1. When is Songkran?

2. What do families give to monks?

3. Where should you put your phone?

D. Your turn

Write two sentences about a festival in your country. When is it? What do people do?

Exercises: Level B1

Name: _____ Date: _____

Word bank: Sanskrit · symbol · relatives · respect · unwritten · waterproof · heritage · monks

A. Complete the sentences. Use six of the words.

1. Water is a _____ of washing away bad luck.
2. Millions of people travel home to see their _____.
3. Pouring water on elders' hands shows _____.
4. There are some _____ rules about who you should not splash.
5. Keep your phone in a _____ bag.
6. UNESCO recognised Songkran as cultural _____.

B. Choose the best answer.

1. What does the word Songkran refer to?
A. a kind of water gun B. the movement of the sun C. a Buddhist temple D. the hottest month
2. What do younger people traditionally do for their elders?
A. give food to monks B. clean the family home C. pour scented water on their hands D. travel to the cities
3. Which person should you NOT splash?
A. a tourist B. a friend with a water gun C. a shopkeeper D. someone on a motorbike

C. Talk about it

1. In your country, do families get together for a festival? What do they do?
2. Is it a good idea for a religious festival to become a tourist event? Why or why not?

Exercises: Level B2

Name: _____ Date: _____

A. Choose the best meaning in the text.

- 'derives from' means
A. replaces B. comes from C. disagrees with D. is similar to
- 'reverence' means
A. humour B. fear C. deep respect D. curiosity
- 'not coincidentally' suggests the link between April and water is
A. an accident B. unlucky C. unknown D. no accident

B. Word formation. Use the word in brackets in the correct form.

- Songkran is a festival of great cultural _____ (important).
- Many visitors want to take part _____ (respect).
- There is ongoing _____ (discuss) about safety on crowded roads.
- The festival's _____ (popular) with tourists has grown.

C. Answer in your own words.

- What does the water symbolise?

- Why are the roads and bus stations crowded before the holiday?

- What discussion is there in Thailand about the modern festival?

D. Discussion

Can a traditional festival stay meaningful when it becomes a global tourist event? Give reasons and an example.

Dialogue: Planning for Songkran

LEVEL B1

Tom: Mali, I'm arriving in Hua Hin on 12 April. Is that a good time to visit?

Mali: It's Songkran, so it'll be busy, and very wet! Do you want to join in?

Tom: Definitely. What should I wear?

Mali: Something light that dries quickly. And you should put your phone in a waterproof bag.

Tom: Good idea. Can I throw water at anyone?

Mali: Mostly people who are playing, yes. But don't splash monks, babies or older people. And never splash someone on a motorbike. It's dangerous.

Tom: Got it. What do you do with your family?

Mali: In the morning we go to the temple and give food to the monks. Then we pour water gently on my grandmother's hands, and she gives us a blessing.

Tom: That sounds lovely. Could I come to the temple with you?

Mali: Of course, but dress modestly. Cover your shoulders and knees.

Tom: Thanks. I'll bring a towel too!

Tasks

1. Underline four phrases that give advice or warnings.
2. Practise the dialogue in pairs. Swap roles.
3. Role-play. Student A is a visitor to your town during a festival. Student B is a local. Ask about clothes, rules, food and what to avoid.
4. Higher level (B2): the visitor wants a quiet, traditional celebration, not the street parties. The local suggests alternatives and gives reasons.

Speaking: My Festival

ALL LEVELS

Step 1. Make notes about a festival you know.

Name and date	
Where and with whom	
What people do	
Special food or clothes	
One thing visitors should know	

Step 2. Tell your partner. Your partner asks two questions.

A2: 'It is on ...' 'People ...' 'We eat ...' 'Visitors should not ...'

B1: 'It takes place in ...' 'The tradition is that ...' 'You should ... / You shouldn't ...'

B2: 'It dates back to ...' 'What makes it special is ...' 'Visitors are expected to ...'

Step 3. Discuss in pairs or as a class.

A2: Which festival in your country is the most fun? Why?

B1: Should tourists join local festivals? What should they do and not do?

B2: Traditions change when more people join in. Is that good, bad, or both? Give an example.

Step 4. Report back.

Tell the class one thing you learned about your partner's festival.

Answer key

Level A2

A. 1 F 2 T 3 T 4 F 5 T

B. 1 C 2 A 3 D 4 B 5 E

C. 1 On 13, 14 and 15 April. 2 Food. 3 In a waterproof bag.

D. Answers vary.

Level B1

A. 1 symbol 2 relatives 3 respect 4 unwritten 5 waterproof 6 heritage (Not used: Sanskrit, monks)

B. 1 B 2 C 3 D

C. Answers vary.

Level B2

A. 1 B 2 C 3 D

B. 1 importance 2 respectfully 3 discussion 4 popularity

C. 1 Cleansing, respect and good fortune. 2 Many people travel to spend the holiday with their families. 3 Whether the spirit of the festival is being lost as it becomes a tourist event, and the safety of crowded roads.

Dialogue (B1), advice and warning phrases

'you should put your phone in a waterproof bag' 'don't splash monks, babies or older people' 'never splash someone on a motorbike' 'dress modestly. Cover your shoulders and knees.'